candidates on March 8. Shailaja Teacher has questioned the fiat. Word is she may opt out if forced.

HEIR LOSS...AND GAIN

Three of Kerala's four politburo members are also out: A. Vijayaraghavan, Viju Krishnan and M.V. Govindan. Talk of a 'sympathy vote' seat for V.A. Arunkumar, son of deceased icon V.S. Achuthanandan, also stands belied for now. Perhaps wise, given how even the high court was moved to harsh words on his elevation from "clerk to director" at an apex institute.

Other parties have heir-raising issues of their own. Late former CM Oommen Chandy's son Chandy Oommen owns home turf Puthuppally. Now his elder daughter, Dr Maria Oommen, wants Kanjirappally. It may not come to pass; the party is keen on AICC secretary Mathew Antony, son-in-law of ex-Supreme Court judge Cyriac Joseph, who has strong family links there and is canvassing church support.

The BJP is not averse to some inherited Christian backing either, with the chances of both Kerala Congress veteran P.C. George and son Shone George shining bright. Padmaja Venugopal, daughter of late Congress strongman K. Karunakaran, is also likely to fulfil the literal meaning of her name—the lotus-born. From Thrissur, where the lotus itself was reborn in 2024. ■

Takeaways

- **Ex-FM Thomas Isaac, three politburo members nixed; 50 of 61 sitting CPI(M) MLAs to recontest**
- **One ex-CM's daughter makes it, two scions miss**

▶ GUJARAT

The Glass Half Full, H

GIFT City gets experimental exemption, as Gujarat navigates



By **Jumana Shah**

PROHIBITION, A THEME THAT neither fills its blanks nor ever dries up in Gujarat, is back doing the only thing it can—taunting itself. The present round of political baiting began in late November, when Congress MLA Jignesh Mevani led a 'janta raid' on an alcohol distribution centre operating next to a school in Tharad town, Banaskantha district. The usual side of unsavoury words and personal accusations heated up the air for a while, after which politicians reverted to pious assertions of their commitment to strict prohibition.

Then, just weeks later, a major exemption in state policy was announced: within GIFT City, non-Gujarat residents and foreigners can now consume liquor in licensed hotels, restaurants and clubs simply by showing a valid photo ID. As for Gujarat residents who are GIFT City employees, they can apply for liquor permit directly to the government, bypassing a special permit via their company. The drinking zones are cordoned off from common areas, and monitored by CCTV cameras; any leftover booze is to be